Voices from the Lowell Mills

Mary S. Paul, a Lowell mill worker · December 21, 1845

Source: Letter of Mary Paul (1845). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> A fifteen-year-old Vermont farm girl who went to work in the Lowell textile mills describes the dangers, long hours, wages, and rhythms of factory life in her own words.

My life and health are spared while others are cut off. Last Thursday one girl fell down and broke her neck which caused instant death. She was going in or coming out of the mill and slipped down it being very icy. The same day a man was killed by the cars. Another had nearly all of his ribs broken. Another was nearly killed by falling down and having a bale of cotton fall on him.

[. . .]

At 5 o'clock in the morning the bell rings for the folks to get up and get breakfast. At half past six it rings for the girls to get up and at seven they are called to the mill. At half past 12 we have dinner are called back again at one and stay till half past seven. I get along very well with my work. I can doff as fast as any girl in our room. I think that the factory is the best place for me and if any girl wants employment I advise them to come to Lowell.